
c4 is a decision, not a ritual

THE MAIN RULE

After 1.d4 d5 and 1.d4 Nf6, c4 is the foundation of this repertoire. Against ...e6, ...c6, ...g6 and ...d6 it also remains a sound way to stay within the course.

THE IMPORTANT EXCEPTION

After 1.d4 e5, play 2.dxe5 and develop against the Englund. The central confrontation requires a concrete answer; simply continuing c4 can concede a pawn and the initiative for no repertoire benefit.

PRACTICAL MOVE-ORDER PREFERENCES

Against the Dutch, use 2.g3 and add c4 later. Against 1...c5, use 2.d5. Against 1...Nc6, use 2.d5 followed by development. These are recommendations, not claims that c4 is illegal or necessarily bad.

USE THE SPACE OFFERED

Against ...b6 or ...b5, the course takes e4 and supports the center. Some rare flank moves also justify e4. Your goal is a coherent position, not forcing every opening back into the same pawn skeleton.

The second-move decision table

1.D4 D5 -> 2.C4 | MAIN REPERTOIRE

Attack the d5 pawn and contest the center. The defense Black chooses next determines your setup.

1.D4 NF6 -> 2.C4 | MAIN REPERTOIRE

Claim central space. Follow with Nf3 against ...e6 or ...g6; against ...c5, gain space with d5.

1.D4 E6 -> 2.C4 | KEEP C4

Do not feel forced to transpose to the French with e4. After ...d5 use the QGD; after ...f5 use the Dutch fianchetto.

1.D4 C6 -> 2.C4 | KEEP C4

Prepare for ...d5 and a Slav. Black may transpose to the Semi-Slav with ...e6.

1.D4 G6 -> 2.C4 | KEEP C4

Build the center and use the fianchetto repertoire. Delayed ...d5 must be distinguished from ...d6.

1.D4 D6 -> 2.C4 | KEEP C4

A sound way to stay within Indian structures. e4 is also possible but adds different move orders.

These recommendations form the course route. Other sound moves exist; learn the reason for the choice.

The second-move decision table

1.D4 F5 -> 2.G3 | DEFER BY CHOICE

The course uses Bg2 and kingside castling before c4. 2.c4 is sound; this is not a tactical prohibition.

1.D4 E5 -> 2.DXE5 | CONCRETE EXCEPTION

Black attacks d4 and offers a pawn. Accept and develop against the Englund; do not play c4 automatically.

1.D4 C5 -> 2.D5 | DEFER BY CHOICE

Take space with tempo against the central challenge. 2.c4 is playable but does not follow this selected route.

1.D4 NC6 -> 2.D5 | DEFER BY CHOICE

Gain space against the knight, then use e4 and Nf3. 2.c4 is possible, but allows different Chigorin-like positions.

1.D4 B6 -> 2.E4 | USE OFFERED SPACE

Build d4-e4, then support e4 against ...Bb7. c4 is playable but is not the course choice.

1.D4 B5 -> 2.E4 | USE OFFERED SPACE

Occupy the center while Black expands on the wing. Do not chase b5 before developing.

These recommendations form the course route. Other sound moves exist; learn the reason for the choice.

The second-move decision table

1.D4 A6 -> 2.C4 | NORMAL DEVELOPMENT

A useful central move; watch a later ...b5 or ...d5. There is no forced punishment of ...a6.

1.D4 A5 -> 2.E4 | PRACTICAL CHOICE

Take the broad center and develop. c4 remains legal and can be sound; this choice exploits the extra space.

1.D4 H6 -> 2.C4 | NORMAL DEVELOPMENT

Continue the central repertoire. ...h6 may restrict Bg5, but it does not change the purpose of c4.

1.D4 H5 -> 2.E4 | PRACTICAL CHOICE

Use the center and develop calmly. Attack the advanced h-pawn only if it creates a concrete benefit.

1.D4 F6 -> 2.E4 | USE OFFERED SPACE

Take the center, then develop. Black has weakened the king and obstructed the natural f6 knight square.

1.D4 NA6 -> 2.E4 | USE OFFERED SPACE

Build a broad center. A knight on the rim is not a reason to neglect your own development.

These recommendations form the course route. Other sound moves exist; learn the reason for the choice.

The next fork after 2.c4

AFTER ...D5 AND ...E6

Use Nf3, then Nc3 against ...Nf6. In the normal ...Be7 QGD, exchange on d5 and develop Bg5. If Black builds the ...e6/...c6 triangle before ...Nf6, choose e3 first to avoid a separate Noteboom route.

AFTER ...D5 AND ...C6

Use Nf3 and Nc3 against ...Nf6. After ...dxc4, a4 fights ...b5. If Black captures before ...Nf6, e3 and a4 are a useful related route. ...e6 leads to the Semi-Slav.

AFTER ...NF6 AND ...E6

Choose 3.Nf3. ...b6 leads to the Queen's Indian, ...Bb4+ to the Bogo, ...d5 to the QGD, and ...c5 usually invites d5 with Benoni or Blumenfeld possibilities.

AFTER ...NF6 AND ...G6

Choose 3.Nf3 and g3. A black d-pawn on d6 points toward the King's Indian; ...d5 immediately means a Grunfeld-type central fight.

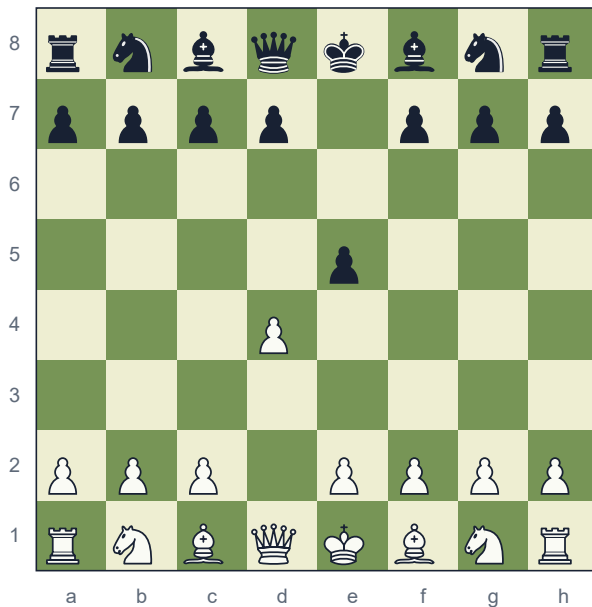
AFTER ...NF6 AND ...C5

Choose d5. ...e6 leads toward the Benoni, ...b5 can be a Benko, and the insertion of ...e6 and Nf3 can create a Blumenfeld.

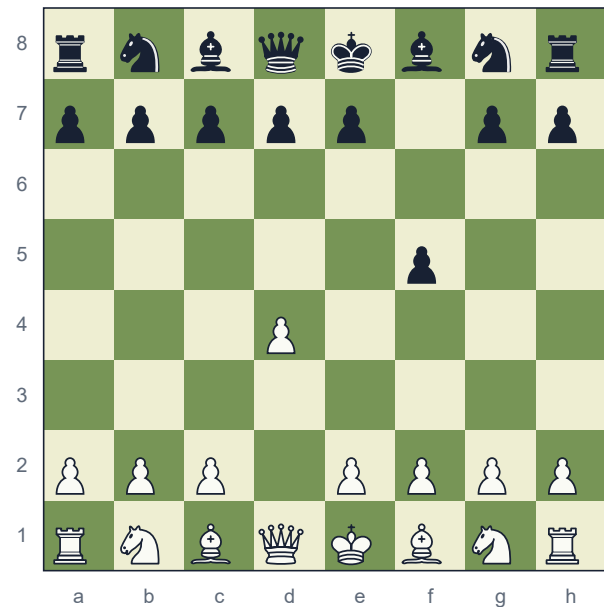
AFTER ...NF6 AND ...E5

Accept with dxe5. ...Ng4 is the Budapest, while ...Ne4 is the Fajarowicz. The exact knight route changes the tactical response.

Two diagrams that prevent two different mistakes



Englund: White to move; play dxe5.



Dutch: White to move; g3 is our choice.

DO NOT CONFUSE THESE REASONS

Against the Englund, Black has directly challenged d4 and offered a pawn; a concrete central response is appropriate. Against the Dutch, g3 is a sound strategic move order that helps your fianchetto development. c4 is also sound there.

YOUR TEST

Without a board, state your second move against ...d5, ...Nf6, ...e5, ...f5, ...c5, ...Nc6 and ...b6. Then explain which choices are tactical responses and which are practical repertoire preferences.

TRANSPPOSITION TEST

Compare 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 Nf6 with 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 d5. The position, side to move and rights agree. Now compare a similar diagram with an extra ...a6: it is not the same position.